# THE CONGRESS A-TEAM

**It takes many hands to win an election. The party leaders who helped tilt the scales**



**MALLIKARJUN KHARGE**

The Congress president and former Karnataka CM contender himself, minutely managed the assembly poll in his home state



**PRIYANKA GANDHI VADRA**

The Congress general secretary campaigned extensively, holding 20-plus rallies and roadshows



**K.C. VENUGOPAL**

The AICC general secretary, organisation, and former AICC Karnataka in-charge played a key role in placating ticket aspirants who had rebelled. Because of his proximity to Rahul Gandhi, his words carried weight



**RAHUL GANDHI**

The Gandhi scion's Bharat Jodo Yatra had covered 21 constituencies in the state. The party won 16 of them

**RANDEEP SURJEWALA**

The AICC general secretary in-charge of Karnataka since 2020 sorted out differences between Siddaramaiah and DKS, apart from working out the nuts and bolts of the Congress strategy



prices and unemployment. The INDIA TODAY-AMI poll shows that inflation was one of the key reasons why the voters went with the Congress, along with the need for 'parivartan' or change of government. Having correctly gauged the mood of the people, the Congress, as Surjewala puts it, "had already fought the elections much, much before the actual dates for polling were announced." Bommai, on the other hand, was lulled into complacency by the mistaken belief that the 'labharthi' or beneficiary vote would accrue to the BJP given that the benefits of central and state welfare schemes reached close to 50 million of the state's 70 million people, and help the party romp to power. He was in for a rude shock.

## LESSON 4: WOO THE COMMON WOMAN

While sticking to its negative messaging on the Bommai government, the core team decided to simultaneously present a positive agenda of hope, choosing to enter the welfare arena with a bang. In January, the party kicked off a Praja Dhwani Yatra (People's Voice March) in Belagavi and announced the first of its five guarantees if voted to power. Shivakumar, flanked by Siddaramaiah and other local leaders, announced Gruha Jyoti, a scheme in which the first 200 units of electricity consumed by a household would be free.

The two leaders then split up in the northern and southward direction and, travelling by bus, covered more than 170 of the state's 224 constituencies, raising local issues and concerns wherever they went. Backing them was a team of nearly 700 professional researchers stationed across the state's 31 districts, tuning in to streetcorner chatter as well as on local social media. They would compile daily pointers for leaders on issues they needed to bring up in every town or village they crossed, giving the party an intimate voter connect. Meanwhile, the Congress unfurled three more guarantees: Gruha Lakshmi, a Rs 2,000 monthly allowance for every woman head of the family; Anna Bhagya, doubling the free distribution of rice and other foodgrains for below the poverty line families to 10 kg; and Yuva Nidhi, a Rs 3,000 monthly allowance to unemployed graduates and Rs 1,500 for diploma-holders for two years.

To ensure every household was made aware of these guarantees, the party got Kanugolo to design them innovatively

THE CONGRESS DID **FALTER ON THE BAJRANG DAL/ BAJRANG BALI ISSUE**, BUT IT EVENTUALLY BACKFIRED ON THE BJP, SINCE THE MUSLIMS VOTED IN LARGE NUMBERS FOR THE CONGRESS